

Bridging Cultural Differences with Critical Design in a Globalized World

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ABSTRACT

Is simplicity and minimalism the universal standard for interaction design? How can we avoid stereotyping with personas in design practices? What AI algorithms and design mechanism made “digital blackface” phenomenon on social media so popular? This interactive course teaches participants to reconsider some commonly held design beliefs and routine design practices with a lens of cultural differences. Illustrated with design case studies, it introduces strategies and techniques to turn differences into design resources for inclusivity. Participants will learn essential critical design skills of creating engaging and empowering designs in a globalized world at a divisive time.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing**; • **HCI design and evaluation methods**; • **Social and professional topics**;

KEYWORDS

Critical design, cultural differences, discursive affordances, bias

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1 BENEFITS

“Design is one of the fundamental ways of power distribution and redistribution” [8]. This course will provide a conceptual foundation with design instruments to advocate for marginalized and disenfranchised user populations and to build networks and coalitions. Participants will develop a critical awareness to reexamine the structural inequality coded in digital technological platforms and explore new design and innovation opportunities for a more inclusive and diverse community and society. Below are the learning outcomes:

- Decode design ideology behind everyday design artifacts and routine design practices
- Understand cultural differences as dynamic and relational concerning cultural values, identity, race, and gender in a globalized world

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- Acquire essential skills to engage cultural differences and turn differences into design resources
- Evaluate designs and explore design and innovation opportunities with a “discursive affordances” design instrument

2 INTENDED AUDIENCE

Design-minded HCI professionals and any HCI professionals who are interested in the topics such as critical design, design ethics, diversity and inclusion, global design, and cross-cultural design, and who are interested in empowering users for more inclusive communities and societies at this divisive time of the globalized world. They will learn a new design instrument and acquire a new design skill. Even people who don’t do design work regularly could still learn from this course since design artifacts are everywhere in our daily lives.

3 PREREQUISITES

There are no prerequisites for this course. Participants need to have some basic cross-cultural design experiences.

4 CONTENT

Are simplicity and minimalism the universal design standards for interaction design? How can we avoid unintended stereotyping with user personas in daily design practices? What AI algorithms and design mechanism made “digital blackface” phenomenon on social media so popular? Why did Facebook’s signup page remain a binary gender option for another five years after the 50+ gender options were introduced in 2014? Why were women’s voices used as default for digital assistants ranging from Apple’s Siri, Microsoft’s Cortana, and Amazon’s Alexa?

To answer design questions as above, this workshop walks participants through design cases and asks them to reconsider some commonly held design beliefs, routine design practices, and everyday design objects with a lens of cultural differences. It introduces strategies and techniques of critical design [7] to create usable, meaningful, and empowering designs to engage cultural differences in a globalized world at a divisive time.

Cultural differences [1–3] emerge from the various categorical identifications such as ethnicity, race, age, class, religion, gender, sexuality, and ability and manifests as ways of life. It is the phenomenon, the reality, the manifestation, the performance, and the consequence of cultural diversity. They provide design challenges because they are often regarded as a deficit or a threat to harmonious communication for understanding [9]. Based on Sun’s longstanding work in cross-cultural, multicultural, and global design [6–8], this course shows that cultural differences are dynamic, relational, emergent, and contingent, and demonstrates ways of engaging cultural differences and turning communication deficits into

generative design resources, as part of the social justice-oriented design.

In this interactive course, a new design instrument of discursive affordances [7, 8] is used to trace the interconnectedness of grand narratives (such as ideologies and cultural institutions) and everyday interactions, and to uncover design and innovation opportunities. Discursive affordances stresses affordances as dialogic discursive relations. It connects critical design considerations for empowerment such as agency, structure, identity, values, ideology, and power on a macrosocial level with design implementations for efficiency and effectiveness out of concrete tasks and various modes of interactions on the micro level. Therefore, it connects macro-HCI with micro-HCI [4]. Visually rich examples will be provided, and hands-on activities also follow for practice.

5 COURSE AGENDA

This online course will be conducted in an interactive workshop format, taking two 75-minute sessions. Below is the course agenda:

- Workshop intro with design icebreaker activity (20 min)
- What is empowering design in a globalized world (20 min): Participatory lecture
- Understanding cultural differences (30 min): Participatory lecture & Workshop activity
- Break (15 min)
- Mapping affordances (30 min): Workshop activity
- Turning differences into design resources (20 min): Participatory lecture & Workshop activity
- Break (15 min)
- Practice session (45 min): Group workshop
- Group demo (25 min)
- Review, take-away, & feedback (20 min)

6 PRACTICAL WORK

A one-hour practice session of group workshop is included (see course agenda above). Participants will apply the design instrument of discursive affordances to come up with design ideas for the offered design scenarios. They will work in a group of four to five for 45 minutes and then share out their ideas. Design feedback will be given during the share-out.

7 INSTRUCTOR BACKGROUND

Associate Professor in cross-cultural, multi-cultural, and global UX design & Associate Director of Global Innovation & Design Lab at University of Washington Tacoma. I teach and practice on how to design and innovate for usable, meaningful, and empowering technology in this globalized world to bridge cultural differences. Oxford University Press book author of *Cross-Cultural Technology Design* (2012) and *Global Social Media Design* (2020). The former won a best technical communication book award from NCTE (National Council of Teachers of English), US, and received endorsements from *Fast Company*, *ACM Crossroads*, *UXPA User Experience Magazine*. I also publish on *Fast Company*, *The Conversation*, and *UXPA Online Magazine*, speak at the top conferences such as SXSW, CHI, and STC Summit, and offer workshops at local SIGs and international conferences such as *IEEE Professional Communication Conference* and

ACM SIGDOC. This course is based on my longstanding research in cross-cultural, multicultural, and global design.

8 RESOURCES

Participants will receive the following handouts: PPT slides, discursive affordances worksheets, workshop activity sheets, sample book chapters, and sample public media article concerning the topic.

9 ACCESSIBILITY

I offered this course in both in-person delivery mode and online delivery mode before. In a recent online workshop when I had a blind participant, I followed the accessible presentation guidelines of SIGACCESS [5] and the following zoom communication protocols with effective results:

Name and pronouns

- If you are comfortable, add your pronouns to your Zoom name. To change your Zoom name, click on Participants at the bottom and then find the Rename option next to your name on the right sidebar.
- Use people's pronouns and if you don't know their pronouns, ask them or use "they".

Video

- Turn your video off if you or your computer are moving around.

Communicating effectively

- Use the "Raise Hand" feature if you want to speak
- Say your name before speaking.
- When addressing other attendees, say their name instead of saying "you" or other non-specific terms.

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